

You'll Be More Than Amused by These 15 Photos of Theme Parks. Their Electrifying Attractions Will Have Your Heart Racing Before You Even Set Foot on a Ride

Genre: Arts-Culture | 221 words

Source: <https://www.smithsonianmag.com/arts-culture/youll-be-more-than-just-amused-by-these-15-photos-of-theme-parks-their-electrifying-attractions-will-have-your-heart-racing-before-you-even-set-foot-on-a-ride-180989008/>

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These images from the Smithsonian Magazine Photo Contest remind us that amusement parks have entertained generations of thrill-seekers

Neon lights illuminate an oddly empty Santa Monica Pier at night.

Jose Lopez Galdamez, California, 2023

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They're called amusement parks, but that name may not accurately capture the fun and fabulousness of these entertainment venues. Their rides, festival fare, arcade-style games and high-altitude attractions are not just amusing; they're what some might describe as magical, sustaining these sites for centuries. The United States has more than 1,000 amusement parks—meaning one is likely within a few hours' drive of your home—and equally awesome counterparts across the world draw millions of adventurers. Carousels, Ferris wheels, roller coasters, giant swings and racing games are just some of the more common features at many big parks internationally. Their appeal is undeniable, and our Smithsonian Magazine Photo Contest entrants are fans. Take a look.